

Fall 2025 MEDPL 150: Visual Communication & Interactive Design

Lecture: Wednesdays 7pm-8:50pm Online via Zoom

<https://us02web.zoom.us/j/83273731583?pwd=qkL9nEL0l1cfVM4VULnOlB9QYg7qoZ.1>

Meeting ID: 832 7373 1583

Passcode: 749832

Instructors:

Ricardo Miranda — Rm. 425D Hunter North; email: rmira@hunter.cuny.edu;

Office hours: MEDPL 150 – Tuesdays 6-7pm

Lab Instructors & Times (Hunter North 432):

Sofia Demopolos sofiademopolos@gmail.com	L01 Th 1:00PM - 2:50PM L02 Th 3:00PM - 4:50PM
Haisi Hu cunymedia150@gmail.com	L03 Th 5:00PM - 6:50PM L04 Th 7:00PM - 8:50PM
Jem Hill writejemhill@gmail.com	L05 Tu 1:00PM - 2:50PM L06 Tu 3:00PM - 4:50PM
Lucia Cozzi lucia.cozzi1@gmail.com	L07 Tu 5:00PM - 6:50PM L08 Tu 7:00PM - 8:50PM
Rachel Jungeun Oh rachel.oh57@cuny.edu	L09 Th 11:00AM - 12:50PM

Course Description: MEDPL 15000 is a liberal arts course that introduces students to the critical theories, analytical tools and practical fundamentals of visual communication, interface design, user experience, digital graphics and illustration, web design, digital photography and new media art in a lecture/lab format. It is a foundations course in 2D and interactive design grounded in critical thinking about digital tools and analytical approaches for examining visual culture.

Learning Outcomes:

- Evaluate evidence and arguments to distinguish movements and significant artists in the history of visual design, computer graphics, illustration, photography, UX and creative computer interactivity.
- Gather, interpret, and assess primary and secondary sources on contemporary issues in visual studies and produce a well-reasoned oral argument about the use of design principles and interaction design in contemporary media, using evidence to support conclusions.
- Create raster and vector graphics applying composition, framing, and layout concepts, demonstrating knowledge of the skills and design principles involved in the visual creative process.

- Plan and apply a comprehensive understanding of HTML and CSS to web design.
- Apply critical concepts learned in class to articulate how meaning is created in the arts and how experience is interpreted and conveyed using current new media art exhibitions as subject.
- Create digital images and apply technical knowledge of the camera's operation to enhance photographic compositions

Each student will create a basic website where they will showcase the work they produce in the course. On their website, students will write about their class experiences and post their assignments. Entries are due on the date indicated in the homework handouts. Each assignment is to be accompanied by a 250-word text reflection.

Course textbooks: We will be using the video tutorial site LinkedIn Learning as our textbook for the semester. Subscription to LinkedIn Learning is available to all Hunter students via your CUNYfirst login. Please follow the instructions on this page to access LinkedIn Learning: <https://hunter.cuny.edu/hunterworks/linkedin-learning/how-to-access/>

Reading Assignments: There are four online reading assignments through the semester. Each reading requires a 500-word written reflection.

Optional Recommended Texts: [*The Language of Graphic Design*](#) by Richard Poulin, purchase is not required, digital copy is available and it's in the library; [*Laws of UX: A Collection of Best Practices When Building User Interfaces*](#) by Jon Yablonski

Adobe Access: Students must create an Adobe ID using CUNYfirst Login username to access the software on the computer in your labs.

***Students must also use an external or cloud drive to backup ALL WORK – back up your work at the end of each lab and back up your homework assignments.**

Brightspace and Lab Instructor Website: Prof. Miranda will post the lecture slides and notes on the MEDPL 150 Brightspace site. There will also be announcements, readings, and other resources available there. In addition, this course will be using a website created by your Lab Instructor, it will also be an integral part of the class. Lab instructors will post material there for exercises and additional resources to enhance your skills. Check Brightspace for general course announcements. If you need help accessing Brightspace please contact Sent help desk at 212-650-3624 or email studenthelpdesk@hunter.cuny.edu

Lab Availability: Open lab hours for HN432 will be listed on the lab doors following the first week. Tech fellows working out of HN435 are available to assist students. Computer labs with the same software are also available in Hunter North 1001A/D for Public Computing Lab info: <https://hunter.cuny.edu/information-technology/services/equipment-support/public-computing/>

Class Participation: By enrolling in this course and entering the classroom, each student makes the tacit commitment to participate in the class. Active class participation involves more than merely attending the online lectures and in-person labs. Students are expected to be actively involved in the class. They should take the initiative in discussions and projects, ask relevant questions, and contribute to the overall learning environment of the class. It is your responsibility:

1. to prepare for class by having completed all assigned work;
2. to actively participate in class discussions and activities;
3. to take notes on discussions, presentations, and course activities;
4. to complete all course assignments, even if you are absent from a class meeting.

Lateness and Absences: Attendance is important in this class because it effects your participation grade, if you are not present you cannot participate, and your grade will suffer. Medical emergencies must be documented to be excused. Being late to class negatively impacts your participation grade. Late assignments can be accepted up to one week late but at a 50% grade reduction.

There will be one exam completed during lecture period via Brightspace. Please note that you must notify your Lab Instructor ahead of time if you cannot attend lecture on the day of an exam to arrange an alternate time for you to take it. This will only be done in cases where there is a well-documented reason for missing the exam date.

NO PERSONAL ELECTRONIC NETWORKING DURING CLASS (incl. cell phones, web surfing, messaging, email, or the use of any social media or media consumption).

Method of Evaluation:

- Projects & Portfolio Website: 35%
- Exam 1: 10%
- Oral Presentation (6 min): 15%
- Exam 2: 10%
- Four Readings & 500 Word Reading Responses: 15%
- In-class exercises, quizzes and participation: 15%

Students will be graded based on the [Hunter College Grading Structure](#).

Details on Method of Evaluation:

1. Weekly Homework Assignments: 35% - Students are required to create a series of hands-on digital media production assignments where they analyze and identify the visual characteristics of an artistic movement and apply these visual communication techniques to an original artwork with a well-executed digital design. Students apply their knowledge and skills using leading raster and vector software. You will post the homework assignments to your Lab's Brightspace on the due date (unless the Lab Instructor instructs otherwise). Each assignment is to be accompanied by a brief 250-word analysis detailing the concept and execution of your visual work.
2. Exam 1 (material from weeks 1-7) & Exam 2 (weeks 9-13): 10% each - The exam will feature short answer questions, True/False, multiple choice and matching questions based on the content presented in lecture and use of the software employed in lab.

3. Oral Presentation: 15% - A six-minute oral presentation supported with visual examples to critically examine the use of design principles across student selected media. The presentation will examine the aesthetic tendencies of the genre the work is in, the technical methods, and the social context of the artwork and provide evidence that supports the student's claims. The supporting visual examples will also be evaluated based on the student's application of design concepts presented in class. The subject matter of the presentation can come from any field of visual communication: art, advertisement, graphics, video game design, web design, etc.
4. Four readings & 500-Word Reading Responses: 15% - The reading reflections should not be a summary of the reading, but rather how you connect to the content and an analysis of the material. Plus one 250-word reflection on the Visiting Artist Lecture.
5. In-class Exercises, Quizzes and Participation: 15% - During the lectures and lab sections, students will be asked to analyze, interpret and discuss a variety of media using a range of critical and aesthetic perspectives. Participation in class discussions where students apply the terms from their readings and the lectures is mandatory. If you are not in class or you are consistently late, your participation grade will be impacted.

Labs: Contact your Lab Instructor first with any questions related to the lab (rather than the lecturer). * **It is your responsibility to know when and where your lab section is meeting.*** The production assignments for this course account for a significant portion of your grade. You should expect to spend time outside of class working on these assignments, hence the open lab hours and available labs in HN1001A/D.

Recording of Remote Classes: The lectures will be recorded so that they may be used as a reference. Students who participate in this class with their camera on or use a profile image are agreeing to have their video or image recorded solely for the purpose of creating a record for students enrolled in the class to refer to, including those enrolled students who are unable to attend live. If you are unwilling to consent to have your profile or video image recorded, be sure to keep your camera off and do not use a profile image. Likewise, students who un-mute during class and participate orally are agreeing to have their voices recorded. If you are not willing to consent to have your voice recorded during class, you will need to keep your mute button activated and communicate exclusively using the "chat" feature.

Academic Integrity: Academic integrity is a guiding principle of the Hunter College learning community because all students should have the opportunity to learn and perform on a level playing field. Academic dishonesty includes, but is not limited to, cheating, plagiarism, obtaining an unfair advantage, and falsifying records or documents, whether intentional or not.

Hunter College upholds the right to promote academic integrity on its campus as an educational institution of the City University of New York. The College has the responsibility to review all charges of academic dishonesty and implement sanctions, including, but not limited to, failing the course, official transcript notation, suspension or

expulsion from the College when it has been determined that academic dishonesty did occur. Please click [here](#) to see a full list of disciplinary sanctions.

Regarding the use of AI: All assignments submitted in this class must be your original work and written by you alone. Copying and pasting from the Internet or another student's work without attributing the source is plagiarism, whether intentional or not. While you may use AI tools like ChatGPT or Grammarly for feedback on how to improve your writing, using any AI tools to write your assignments is strictly prohibited and will be treated as plagiarism. Anyone presenting someone else's writing as their own, whether from another student, the Internet or any AI tool generating text that is copied into your work, will receive a 0 for the assignment and will be reported to the Office of Student Conduct. You are welcome to use text-to-image AI tools to help brainstorm your initial ideas, but you must execute your own projects. Use AI as a tool, NOT as a replacement of your imagination and critical thinking. Copying and pasting HTML & CSS is permitted, once you understand what you are copying and pasting.

Office of AccessABILITY Statement: In compliance with the American Disability Act of 1990 (ADA) and with Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act of 1973, Hunter College is committed to ensuring educational parity and accommodations for all students with documented disabilities and/or medical conditions. It is recommended that all students with documented disabilities (Emotional, Medical, Physical, and/or Learning) consult the Office of Accessibility located in Room E1124 to secure necessary academic accommodations. For further information and assistance, please call (212) 772-4857/TTY (212) 650-3230. If you have registered with the Office of Accessibility, please let me know at the start of the term.

Emergency/Crisis Info: This is a list of Hunter College phone numbers, which you can use if there is an emergency or personal crisis or if you need assistance at other times. Security - B-1 Level West Building - 212-772-4444; Counseling & Wellness Services (CWS) – 1123 East Building – 212-772-4931; <https://hunter.cuny.edu/students/health-wellness/>

CUNY Policy on Sex-Based Misconduct: In compliance with the CUNY Policy on Sexual Misconduct, Hunter College reaffirms the prohibition of any sexual misconduct, which includes sexual violence, sexual harassment, and gender-based harassment, retaliation against students, employees, or visitors, as well as certain intimate relationships. Students who have experienced any form of sexual violence on or off campus (including CUNY-sponsored trips and events) are entitled to the rights outlined in the Bill of Rights for Hunter College. Sexual Violence: Students are strongly encouraged to immediately report the incident by calling 911, contacting NYPD Special Victims Division Hotline (646-610-7272) or their local police precinct or contacting the College's Public Safety Office (212-772-4444). All Other Forms of Sexual Misconduct: Students are also encouraged to contact the College's Title IX Campus Coordinator, Dean John Rose (jtrose@hunter.cuny.edu or 212-650-3262) or Colleen Barry (colleen.barry@hunter.cuny.edu or 212-772-4534) and seek complimentary services through the Counseling and Wellness Services Office, Hunter East 1123. CUNY Policy on Sexual Misconduct. Link: <https://www.hunter.cuny.edu/public-safety/policies/sexual-assault-and-misconduct/>

Rockowitz Writing Center: 7th Floor of the library is where students receive tutoring in reading and writing skills, critical reading, and the writing process. Students can apply for a weekly appointment with a tutor and/or use drop-in services during scheduled hours. Students may also attend workshops offered at the Center throughout the academic year. <https://hunter.cuny.edu/rockowitz-writing-center/>

Course Schedule

The schedule is subject to change. Homework assignments are packaged with the syllabus but are as well subject to change. Syllabus and Homework Assignments will be available on Brightspace or via your lab instructors' course site. All homework is due before your lab section meets unless instructed otherwise.

Week 1: Introduction

Lecture: 9/2 - Course Overview: Visual Studies in Digital Media

Labs: Tue 9/1, Thu 9/3 - Students brainstorm a personal creative statement and photograph with the DSLR camera and import their footage via Adobe Bridge to Adobe Photoshop.

Homework 1: Cropping and Resizing Images & Tonal Range due 9/8 for Tue, and 9/10 for Thu labs. Reading: ch.1 "In Plato's Cave" from *On Photography* by Susan Sontag, 500-word reflection due 9/8, 9/10

Week 2: Photography

Lecture: 9/9 - Photography

Labs: 9/8, 9/10 - Students use the DSLR cameras on campus to make images for Homework 3 Depth of Field: in-camera and digital assignment. Students upload the images to their computers via Adobe Bridge, edit the photos in Photoshop, export for the web.

Homework 2: Depth of Field due 9/15, 9/17

Week 3: Collage, Photomontage and Compositing

Lecture: 9/16 - Collage, Photomontage and Compositing

Labs: 9/15, 9/17 – Photograph or select images for Photomontage assignment and begin editing. Introduction to Masks and Blend Modes.

Homework 3: Social Campaign: this is a two-part design assignment – the first part is to create a photomontage and the second part (homework 4) is to add text and vector elements as design components to create a socially engaged advertisement – part 1 **due by end of lab** Tue 9/30, Thu 10/1. Reading: [Your Brain on ChatGPT](#) and watch: [Brain Experts WARNING: Watch This Before Using ChatGPT Again!](#) 500-word reflection due Tue 9/30, Thu 10/1.

Week 4: Design Basics

Lecture: 9/23 – Introduce Elements and Principles of Graphic Design

Labs: 9/22, 9/4 – Introduction to Illustrator: Layers, Shapes, Transforming Objects, Pen Tool.

Homework 4: Copy, paste, re-size and place Illustrator shapes onto socially engaged photomontage. Continue working on the Social Campaign by adding vector elements (text, shape, pattern, illustration...) to the photocollage - due Tue 10/13, Thu 10/15 by end of lab.

Week 5: Type, Layouts and Grids

Lecture: 9/30 - Type, Layouts and Grids

Labs: Tue 9/29, Thu 10/1 – Illustrator: Fills & Strokes, Color, Complex Shapes (may begin homework 5).

Homework 5: In lab exercise (**Tue 10/6, Thu 10/8**): Using 2 shapes, 2 complementary colors create an eye that expresses an emotion such as fear or surprise or sadness or anger. Reading assignment: [“Graphic Novel: Motherhood in crisis”](#) by Laurence Ivil, Alicia Prager and Saidu Bah, 500-word reflection due Tue 10/27, Thu 10/29.

Week 6: Color, Pattern, and Illustration

Lecture: 10/7 – Color, Pattern & Illustration

Lab: Tue 10/6 Thu 10/8 – Review for exam & Illustrator: Using Raster Graphics, Pen Tool, Type; complete Homework 5.

Homework 6: Illustrated Environment due Tue 11/3, Thu 10/29.

Week 7: Exam 1

Lecture: 10/14 – Exam 1 will be available from 7-7:50pm (with more time for students registered with the Office of Accessibility, if so, please pause for the artist lecture); followed by visiting artist lecture – artist/ animator [Sara Stern](#) from 8-8:50pm

Labs: Tue 10/20 (10/13 follows Monday schedule), Thu 10/15 Work on Illustrated Environment.

Homework 6: Continue Illustrated Environment, due Tue 11/3, Thu 10/29. Write a ~250-word reflection on Sara Stern's presentation, due Tue 10/27, Thu 10/22.

Week 8: Animation

Lecture: 10/21 - A History of Animation

Labs: Tue 10/27, Thu 10/22 – Creating animated gifs using Adobe Illustrator & Photoshop; work on Illustrated Environment or animate with the Photoshop Timeline.

Homework 7: Animated GIFs due Tue 11/17, Thu 11/13

Week 9: Games

Lecture: 10/28 - A History of Games

Lab: Tue 11/3, Thu 10/29 – Review Illustrated Environment. Continue working on animated gifs using Adobe Illustrator & Photoshop.

Homework 7: Animated GIFs due Tue 11/10, Thu 11/5.

Week 10: Internet

Lecture: 11/4 - The Internet: History, Aesthetics & Current Issues

Lab: Tue 11/10, Thu 11/5 – Introduction to HTML: headers, paragraphs, images and hyperlinks; introduction to Github.

Homework 8: Create an online portfolio that presents each of your projects, working version due Tue 11/24, Thu 11/19. **Reading assignment:** Nuclear War: [The Rising Risk, and How We Stop It](#), write a 500-word reflection and add this

reflection to your “readings.html” page, due Tue 12/1, Thu 12/3.

Week 11: Information Graphics and Data Visualization

Lecture: 11/11 – Information Graphics and Data Visualization

Lab: Tue 11/17, Th 11/12 – 6-minute oral presentations; Introduction to CSS, continue working on your course portfolio - CSS resource: <https://www.w3schools.com/css/default.asp> ; CSS examples: <http://www.csszengarden.com/> ; CSS Intro Course CH1 Getting Started: <https://www.linkedin.com/learning/css-essential-training-22688362>

Homework 8: Continue working on portfolio due Tue 11/24, Thu 11/19 and cover the reading due Tue 12/1, Thu 12/3.

Week 12: Digital Affordances

Lecture: 11/18 – Digital Affordances

Lab: Tue 11/24, Thu 11/19 – 6-minute oral presentations; continue introduction to CSS

Homework 9: Interactive Story – brainstorm ideas for an interactive story to share with a classmate during the next lab.

Week 13: Critical Media Making & Semester in Review

Lecture: 12/2 – Emerging Media Research & Review for Exam 2

Lab: Tue 12/1, Thu 12/3 share and begin building Interactive Story, due 12/18 along with completed course portfolio.

Week 14: Interactive Story

Lecture: 12/9 – Exam 2

Lab: Tue 12/8, Thu 12/10 work on Interactive Story.

Homework 10: Finalize Portfolio Website and Complete Interactive Story due by 6pm Friday 12/18 FOR ALL LABS.

Homework:

Homework must be submitted to your Lab Instructor prior to the lab class, unless the syllabus or lab instructor states otherwise. Questions from assigned reading, video tutorials and lecture will be on exams and quizzes. Required readings and tutorials are listed for each assignment, there may be pop quizzes in your lab sections based on any assigned material. Video tutorials are on LinkedIn Learning, please access your account: <https://hunter.cuny.edu/hunterworks/linkedin-learning/>

Each homework requires an approximately 250-word written reflection. A reflection should not be a listing of what you did. It should present the ideas and meaning in the work that you create. The rationale behind the written statements are to expand your creative language and engage with your work beyond technical skills to being a critical and creative media maker.

Similarly, there are assigned readings and reflections to the readings. The reflections should not be a summary; it should be a thoughtful analysis of the reading. The reflections should not be a summary; it should be a thoughtful analysis of the reading. The reading reflections will be submitted to your lab's Brightspace.

**Homework 1: Cropping and Resizing Images & Tonal Range
due Tuesday 9/8, Thursday Labs 9/10.**

Optional for anyone new to the Mac OS: [Mac Tutorial for Beginners / Windows Users by Anson Alexander](#) (39min)

Required Reading: “In Plato’s Cave” chapter 1 from *On Photography* by Susan Sontag, 1977 available as PDF from Brightspace, 500-word reflection due, Tue 9/8, Thu 9/10.

Required Viewing: From LinkedIn Learning “[Photoshop 2025 Essential Training](#)” (please try following along with your own images):

- ch 4. Digital Image Essentials sections (all tutorials)
- ch 6. Cropping, Straightening, and Adjusting Canvas Size (first three tutorials)
- ch 7. Layers (first tutorial)
- ch. 13. Adjustment Layer Essentials (first three tutorials)

Part 1) The opening chapter from Susan Sontag’s *On Photography* reflects upon the power of image taking. Well before the advent of the smart phone, Sontag discusses the ubiquity of the camera and image taking. This is the longest reading of the semester for this course. The reading is assigned to place image making in a critical context. What does it mean to you to capture images and create graphics? Through the length of the semester, you will be asked to realize ten projects, each project quite different from the other as you are asked to use various tools. Although each project is distinct, please consider them as a body of work; consider how one may relate to the

next and how you as a media maker can build from one to the next. Please write a 500-word reflection on how you use photography and image making. How could you represent visually through photography or illustration or the combination of image and text notions of our world at this moment? Unless instructed otherwise by your Lab Instructor, submit the 500-word reflection to your Lab's Brightspace.

Part 2) Based on the composition and framing concepts that were covered in the lecture, take at least five photos with lab DSLR cameras. Tuesday labs will do this during second meeting.

Choose the two images that you think are compositionally the most compelling and save a copy of both images in their original pixel dimensions (in other words, keep a back-up of the original file). Crop a copy of one of the images to 1920 px by 1080 px and crop a copy of the other image to 5"x7". Now, modify the Tonal Range of the two images using an adjustment layer following the steps in chapters above. Export these as jpg images and make sure they are under 2 MB in their file size. Unless instructed otherwise by your Lab Instructor, submit your photographs to your Lab's Brightspace.

Homework 2: Depth of Field **due Tuesday 9/15, Thursday Labs 9/17.**

Required Viewing: From LinkedIn Learning "[Photoshop 2025 Essential Training](#)":

- ch. 5 Adobe Camera Raw
- ch. 15 Smart Object Essentials
- ch. 18 Essential Filters

[How to Create a Lens Blur Effect in Photoshop](#)

[How to Read Histogram in Photoshop \(Fix Exposure & Color Fast\)](#)

Part 1: Take two photographs with the same composition and exposure. One photograph with a shallow depth of field and the second one with a deep depth of field. Try creating multiple pairs of photographs with shallow and deep depth of field to experiment with shutter speed, aperture and ISO. Compare your experience behind the lens with the tutorial above (The blur gallery) by creating a shallow depth-of-field effect with an image that you shot. Post one shallow depth of field, one deep depth of field and one Photoshopped Lens Blur image to your Lab Instructor's Brightspace. Make sure the images are under 2 MB in their file size by saving for the web.

Part 2: Using the Camera Raw filter in Photoshop, adjust the exposure of two images. Using the tutorial linked above, follow the steps that show how to deal with underexposure, clipping warnings and the histogram. In addition, use the straighten tools in the Camera Raw filter to level and straighten your images. Save the before and after images and post them to your Lab Instructor's Brightspace.

Homework 3 Due: Social Campaign – Photomontage
due Tue Lab 9/30, Thu Labs 10/1

Required Reading: [Your Brain on ChatGPT](#) and watch: [Brain Experts WARNING: Watch This Before Using ChatGPT Again!](#) 500-word reflection due Tue 9/30, Thu 10/1.

This is a two-part project split over two homework assignments that expand your Photoshop toolset and introduces you to Illustrator to combine Photomontage with Vector Design.

Photomontage (Lab 4 – Tue 9/22, Thu 9/24)

Required Viewing: From LinkedIn Learning “[Photoshop 2025 Essential Training](#)”:
ch. 9 Working with Layer Masks and Clipping Masks (all tutorials)
ch. 10 Making Selections (first two tutorials)
ch. 14 Blend Mode Essentials (all tutorials)

The Week 3 lecture presents the photomontage as political commentary, cultural critique, express the subconscious or create self-portraits. For this assignment, create two photomontages that use masking and at least one blending mode to present a message. Brainstorm a political or social or ecological issue that interests you and utilize this issue to inform your images and design.

Each photomontage should combine at least three images; however, you may want to do many more. Make precise selections and use masking to combine different elements of your image. Like the images we saw in class, your photomontage should have a concept that drives the selection and juxtapositions of images. Review the discussion of blending modes in the lecture and consider how you may use blending techniques creatively. In addition, consider the role of scale, rhythm and texture in your composition. In your pieces, try to use as many images as possible that you have shot, are in the public domain; one resource is: [Wikimedia Commons](#).

Both of your finished images should be 5”x7” and posted to your Lab’s Brightspace as jpg images. Please also include a screenshot of both of your PSD working files including an expanded view of your layers panel. With this project write a two-paragraph explanation of the concepts you are exploring and what techniques you employed to achieve the results. Describe which blending mode(s) you chose and why. Make sure to also discuss the source of your images, are they from online or photos you shot or some other source...

Homework 4 Due: Social Campaign – Photomontage & Design (Lab 5 – 9/29, 10/1)
due Tue 10/13, Thu 10/15 by end of lab.

Required Viewing: From LinkedIn Learning “[Illustrator 2025 Essential Training](#)”
Introduction: Anchor display

- ch. 1 The Illustrator Environment
- ch. 2 Selection
- ch. 3 Shape and Line Tools
- ch. 4 Path Drawing
- ch. 5 Transforms
- ch. 8 Strokes
- ch. 10 Organizing Content
- ch. 13 Using Grids and Guides

Create a new Illustrator document and use the following preferences: Profile: Art & Illustration; Size: 1920 x 1080 pt; Orientation: Landscape; Artboards: 1; Bleed: 0; Advanced Options - Color Mode: RGB Color; Raster Effects: High (300 points per inch); Preview Mode: Default

Design Elements in Photomontage - from Illustrator to Photoshop

Using at minimum 1 repeating shape with 1 color create a design that will be incorporated into your Photomontage (view the Grid, Rulers & Guides and Smart Guides to help you). You may elect to add more elements such as text and other shapes to try different designs. Consider using symmetry or asymmetry as well as other design concepts.

Select and copy the vector designs and/or text from Illustrator and paste it into Photoshop Photomontage Document as a Smart Object. In Photoshop, resize, rotate and transform as necessary to integrate the vector design. Save for the web and submit to Lab's Brightspace.

Homework 5: In-Lab Vector Emotive Eye - Tue 10/6, Thu 10/8, 10/10; at home reading and 500-word reflection due Tue Labs 10/27, Thu Labs 10/29.

Required Viewing: From LinkedIn Learning "[Illustrator 2025 Essential Training](#)"

- ch. 6 Color
- ch. 7 Gradients
- ch. 11 Groups
- ch. 12 Drawing Made Easier
- ch. 14 Patterns

Using 2 shapes, 2 complimentary colors and up to 2 line styles create an eye that expresses an emotion such as fear or surprise or sadness or anger. It may be life-like, cartoon-like, or fantastic, but it must convey an emotion. Make it large - use the majority of the Artboard. Name your layers and name the shape sub-layers in a way that is easy for you to identify the various shapes or lines. Try viewing the Grid, Rulers & Guides and Smart Guides to help you along. Save this image as a png file and post it to your Lab's Brightspace.

Required Reading: [Graphic Novel: Motherhood in crisis](#), by Laurence Ivil, Alicia Prager and Saidu Bah, Al Jazeera

Choose one of the motherhood stories and write a paragraph considering why illustration was used. Each story combines text, illustration, photography and video.

Visually how do the illustrations vary from the photographs? What advantage may they present in comparison to text only or photography? Submit the 500-word reflection to Lab's Brightspace, due 10/27, 10/29.

Homework 6: Illustrated Environment **due Tue Labs 11/3, Thu Labs 10/29**

Required Viewing: From LinkedIn Learning "[Illustrator 2025 Essential Training](#)"

- ch. 15 Appearances
- ch. 16 Transparency
- ch. 17 Type
- ch. 18 Images and Files
- ch. 21 Output

Using Adobe Illustrator import a raster image of an environment, this may be a photograph from a city block, a natural environment, an interior – any setting that you wish. Use the photograph as a template in its own layer to create an illustrated version of the setting (be sure to lock the photo layer). Use a combination of all the tools that Illustrator offers to transform the environment; **do not merely use Image Trace**. Make use of layers to separate foreground, middle ground and background. You may only use three colors in this assignment. Use the Adobe Color CC website - <https://color.adobe.com/> to create a Triad color theme for the illustrated environment. This should be a 1920 x 1080 Artboard. Use Export > Export for Screens... to save for the web as a png and submit to Lab's Brightspace. Write a paragraph about the environment describing why you chose it and how you transformed it.

Homework 7: 2 Animated GIFs **due Tue Labs 11/17, Thu Labs 11/13**

Required Viewing: "[Photoshop 2025 Essential Training](#)":

- ch. 8 Color and Brush Essentials
- ch. 11 Retouching and Removing Distracting Elements
- ch. 16 Essential Transformation
- ch. 25 Animating Images

Photoshop Puppet Warp:

<https://youtu.be/dcs-oTcX1II?si=jP3qyRP9ThLNoyVN>
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xRGt7byhS50>

Create a series of animated gifs using Adobe Illustrator and Photoshop, beyond the video tutorials above, these technical reference may be helpful:

"Create frame animations" - <https://helpx.adobe.com/photoshop/using/creating-frame-animations.html>

"Animation Panel Overview" https://helpx.adobe.com/photoshop/using/video-animation-overview.html#switch_animation_modes

“How to Make an Animated GIF” <https://helpx.adobe.com/photoshop/how-to/make-animated-gif.html>

GIF 1: Blink

Revisit the exercise started in your lab section that uses the eye drawing created with Adobe Illustrator from homework #5 to make the drawing blink.

GIF 2: Cut Up Cinema

- Create photographs of yourself or friend(s). Be sure to photograph against a high-contrast solid background to make it easier to mask the figure.
- In Photoshop cut the person out of the image to create a digital puppet.
- Use Puppet Warp Tool to animate the cropped photography
- Duplicate your person into various frames.
- In each frame create variations of the person using the Puppet Warp tool.
- Open the Timeline panel and create a “Frame Animation”.
- By presenting each layer on different frames create an animation of you or a friend in various positions.
- Add background layers or more people or text... Have fun with it.

Homework 8: Online Portfolio Assignment due Tue 11/24, Thu 11/19

Required Reading/Viewing:

<https://www.htmldog.com/guides/html/beginner/> - “Getting Started” through “Images” (8 sections, “Next Page” is linked near bottom of each page) & View tutorial video “Introduction to HTML” (approximately 9 minutes): <https://youtu.be/KuLYc6aT9ZU>

Create a free [Github](#) account and use Github Pages to create a site for the course.

Reading assignment due Tue 12/8, Thu 12/10: [The Rising Risk, and How We Stop It](#), by W. J. Hennigan, NY Times. Write a 500-word reflection that considers how web page interaction, animation, photo, video and data visualization enhance the text. Submit to your lab’s Brightspace.

Homework 9: Interactive Story Assignment due Friday 12/18 for all labs

Required Viewing: From LinkedIn Learning

“[Photoshop 2025 Essential Training](#)”:

ch. 12 Generative AI

“[Illustrator 2025 Essential Training](#)”:

ch. 19 Generative Content

ch. 21 Artboards

Adobe Firefly: <https://www.adobe.com/products/firefly.html>

2 Part Interactive Story due by 6pm, Friday 12/18 for all labs:

A. Planning/Mapping due Tue Labs 12/1 and Thu Labs 12/3

B. HTML-based functioning Interactive Story due by Friday 12/18 for all labs

Create a web-based non-linear story. For this assignment, you can use photography, illustration, montage, generative AI, and text to create a narrative with multiple story paths that can be navigated using hyperlinks. The story and text must be entirely created by you. You may use Adobe Firefly or built-in Photoshop and Illustrator AI tools for the imagery.

1. Map out your narrative, using Illustrator or simply a pencil and paper.
2. Develop the imagery/text for each page.
3. Create a Github repo for this assignment to save a series of html pages dedicated to this project.
4. Make sure your repo homepage is titled index.html and the following story pages should be pg01.html, pg02.html...

There must be at least three possible endings There must be multiple ways to get to each one.

Tip: If you are having trouble coming up with a story, you could make it location-specific... Define one or more locations in NYC that you find interesting. Document the location(s) with several photographs. Write a brief story about the location(s) and give it alternate paths. The story may document something that happened at the location or something more fantastic. Give your user choices to move through the location(s), perhaps something different happens in the story or to your user based on the choices.

Use text or buttons or the images themselves as the hyperlinks.

Developing Creative Statements

First Draft: Week 1; Final Draft: Week 14

A good Creative Statement supplements the visual information in a portfolio so that the reader/viewer can better understand the work.

Compose your statement with a sympathetic friend in mind, one who is genuinely interested in the work and wants to know the answers to questions that may come up when viewing it. To get started with the writing of a statement, begin by describing the type of creative work that you wish to do. For our course, consider fictional narrative or social documentary in the form of photography, illustration, animation, video games, interactive storytelling... For the initial artist statement, pair up with a peer and prompt one another with questions such as what visual work do you enjoy, what aesthetics, what forms of production do you already execute, how can you make the most of this course.... Take notes as you talk.

Keep the creative statement as short as possible – 250 words, approximately 2 paragraphs. It is an introduction and a supplement to the visual information, not your life story. Your statement should stand on its own: so that the reader can imagine what your work looks like even if they haven't seen it. Make the reader want to see your work. You will revisit and either edit or entirely rewrite your artist statement with your online portfolio.

Examples of Brief Creative Statement

Mark Ramos is a Brooklyn-based new media artist. Mark makes fragile post-colonial technology using web/software programming, physical computing (using computers to sense and react to the physical world), and digital sculpture/fabrication to create interactive work that facilitate encounters with our own uncertain digital futures. Mark is deeply committed to the ethos of open source: the free sharing of information and data + creative uses of technology. <https://www.markhramos.net/>

Dina Kelberman is a multimedia artist whose work comes out of a tendency to fastidiously collect and organize imagery from the surroundings of everyday life -- Google, YouTube, television, social media. Her practice utilizes the recontextualization of found media to create monuments to the human need to connect, create, and destroy. Her uncannily meticulous work has been referred to as a 'reverse Turing-test' and an 'elevation of the ugly and boring to beautiful.' Kelberman's work transcends the typical aesthetics of net-art while remaining rooted in the world wide web. <http://dinakelberman.com/>

Danielle Brathwaite Shirley, artist living and working in Berlin. I create work that seeks to archive Black Trans Experience. I use technology to imagine our lives in environments that centre our bodies.... Those living, those that have passed and those that have been forgotten. You think you came here to enjoy some art. You are mistaken. This is about you. How you feel is the medium I am working with. You may feel uncomfortable. You may feel represented. But you won't feel forgotten. <https://www.daniellebrathwaiteshirley.com/>

Video biography by computational artist [Memo Akten](#)

6-Minute Oral Presentation

In-Labs: Tue 11/17 & 11/24, Thu 11/12 & 11/19

The central idea for this assignment is to apply the concepts we are learning in the lectures to your daily visual observations. The art of creating a well-organized and insightful oral/visual presentation is something that will help you in any career. This assignment is intended to help strengthen your ability to gather, interpret and assess information from multiple sources and points of view to produce a well-reasoned oral argument.

The Oral Presentation is an approximately 6-minute presentation supported with visual examples to critically examine the use of design principles in print, digital graphics, web or app design. The presentation will examine the aesthetic tendencies of the genre the work is in, the technical methods, and the social context of the artwork and provide evidence that supports the student's claims. The supporting visual examples, the graphics and typography shown in your slides will be evaluated based on the student's application of design concepts learned in class. The subject matter of the presentation can come from any mass media field of visual communication: advertisement, video game design, mobile app design, website design, etc. Your presentation should include at least one question for your peers related to design elements or principles (see 'd' below). Check with your Lab Instructor for the scheduled date of your presentation. The Oral Presentation counts as 15% of your overall grade.

To help make this assignment more concrete, I've listed some possible examples below. Please do not let these limit the subject you are considering, the idea is to have you apply these concepts to areas of your interest.

Examine the use of color, shape, line and typography in an advertisement you might see in the subway and how design principles like unity, proportion, hierarchy and variety are created with these elements. Make sure to take photos of any ads or billboards as they are seen in public. You may want to focus on an establishing shot and close-up details in your slide images to help orient the viewer or to draw their attention to a subtle element of your media.

Analyze how size, space, point, texture, value and tone work together to create a sense of rhythm, scale, balance and hierarchy in an static or motion graphic. Due to time limitations for your presentation focus on the elements of design that most convincingly argue your point.

Another approach you can take is to describe the overall feeling an image is generating like dread, anguish, joy, security, or bliss and explain how the elements and principles of design are being used to generate this emotion. If there is a person in your media, do not spend a lot of time analyzing their emotions, gestures, etc. we are primarily interested in looking at how the elements of design are being leveraged by designers and media makers to construct our visual culture.

Your question should try to enlist a dialog with the other students about the topic you are discussing. The question might relate to design similarities/dissimilarities within the genre of the artwork or design techniques that are used across genres to convey similar emotions.

Regardless of your subject, your oral presentation should articulate how meaning is created in the media arts and how experience is interpreted and conveyed. In the lectures we will be practicing this process together to help you have a model for your analysis.

EXTRA CREDIT Opportunity (each institution listed is free with CUNY ID or has free days/times). There are two extra credit opportunities. The first must be

completed prior to the first exam, 10/14 and the second prior to the second exam 12/9 as five percent will be added to the corresponding exam. Attend one of the exhibitions below and write a 500-1000 word reflection accompanied with photos that you took of the exhibition. Post the extra credit reflections and images to your readings.html page.

Governors Island – Outside Linear Times, on view until 11/2

<https://www.govisland.com/things-to-do/ongoing-programs/harvestworks>

Whitney Museum of American Art – A History of Internet Art, opens 11/21

<https://whitney.org/exhibitions/artport-25>

Society of Illustrators – Balbusso Twins, until 9/12; All Around Us, until 10/24

<https://societyillustrators.org/>

Asia Society - Busy, Busy Towns: Moving Images of a Changing Asia

<https://asiasociety.org/new-york/exhibitions/busy-busy-towns-moving-images-changing-asia>

MoMA – Full Disclosure, opens 9/27

<https://www.moma.org/calendar/exhibitions/5926>

Poster House – review any exhibition on view

<https://posterhouse.org/exhibitions/>

Museum of the Moving Image (free Thur 2-6pm) – Terms of Agreement, until 10/25;

Overexposed: Art, Technology, and the Body

<https://movingimage.org/whats-on/exhibitions/>

Pioneer Works <https://pioneerworks.org/programs/opening-reception-for-tuomas-a-laitinen-lajune-mcmillan-and-finnegan-shannon-with-ariana>

opening 9/11, 7-9pm

New Art City (online) - <https://newart.city/> Select and explore any work of interest

Other extra credit exhibitions or events may be announced in lecture.